

New Homeowner Survival Guide

Everything they don't tell you when you buy your first home.

GUIDE	PAGES	PRICE
#09	80	Pay What You Want

IMPORTANT NOTICE

This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute professional legal, financial, or medical advice. Always consult qualified professionals for decisions specific to your situation. GrowthVault and its authors accept no liability for actions taken based on this material.

© 2026 GrowthVault · growthvault.co · All rights reserved.

01

CHAPTER 1

The First 30 Days

Critical tasks to do immediately after moving in

The first month of homeownership is the most important. There are time-sensitive tasks that, if missed, can create real problems.

First 30 Days Critical Checklist

- Change all exterior door locks (you don't know who has keys)
- Locate the main water shut-off valve and test it
- Locate the electrical panel — label all breakers
- Locate the gas shut-off and know how to use it
- Test all smoke detectors and carbon monoxide detectors
- Change HVAC filter (many are overdue at purchase)
- Flush all drains and check under sinks for leaks
- Check attic and basement for signs of water damage or pests
- Update your address with USPS, bank, employer, and subscriptions
- Purchase homeowner's insurance if not already active
- Find and photograph all shut-off valves, panels, and mechanical systems

- Meet your neighbors (ask about the neighborhood, local contractors)

02

CHAPTER 2

Understanding Your Home Systems

What every owner needs to know about HVAC, plumbing, and electrical

HVAC: Know your system type (forced air, heat pump, radiator). Replace filters every 1–3 months depending on type. Schedule professional HVAC tune-up twice yearly (before summer and winter). Average lifespan: furnace 15–20 years, AC 10–15 years. Budget accordingly. Plumbing: Know your main water shut-off. Know where individual shut-offs are under sinks and behind toilets. Dripping faucets cost money — fix them. Slow drains become blocked drains. Snake them early. Electrical: Know your panel. Never put a higher-amp breaker on a circuit. GFCI outlets should be in all wet areas — test them monthly. Signs of electrical issues: frequently tripping breakers, flickering lights, warm outlets.

03

CHAPTER 3

Seasonal Maintenance Calendar

What to check every month of the year

Spring: HVAC tune-up, clean gutters, check roof for winter damage, inspect foundation for cracks, test sprinkler system. Summer: Window and door weatherstripping, check deck for rot, clean dryer vent, pest

prevention. Fall: HVAC tune-up, drain exterior hoses, clean gutters (again), check weatherstripping, test smoke and CO detectors. Winter: Check pipes in vulnerable areas, clear snow from roof if heavy, inspect attic insulation, reverse ceiling fans.

04

CHAPTER 4

The Home Emergency Fund

How much to save — and where to keep it

The standard recommendation is 1% of home value per year for maintenance. On a \$300,000 home, that's \$3,000/year or \$250/month. Older homes: budget 1.5–2%. Newer homes: 0.5–1% may be sufficient. Keep this in a high-yield savings account separate from your regular emergency fund. Label it 'Home Maintenance' so you don't spend it on other things. Common first-year surprises: appliance failure (\$500–3,000), roof repair (\$1,000–10,000), HVAC repair (\$300–2,000), plumbing issue (\$200–5,000).

05

CHAPTER 5

First Year Budget

Property taxes, insurance, utilities, and the costs nobody warned you about

True monthly homeownership cost = Mortgage + Property Tax (1/12 of annual) + Homeowner's Insurance (1/12 of annual) + HOA (if applicable) + Utilities + Maintenance Reserve (\$250/month baseline). Utility shock is real: many buyers underestimate utility costs significantly. Ask the seller for 12 months of utility

bills before closing if possible.

06

CHAPTER 6

DIY vs. Hire It Out

The decision framework for every repair situation

DIY confidently: painting, minor landscaping, caulking, changing light fixtures (if comfortable), replacing outlets and switches (if comfortable), installing ceiling fans, drywall patching. Always hire: electrical panel work, plumbing beyond drain/faucet, structural work, roof replacement, HVAC replacement, anything requiring a permit. The permit question is key: if a job requires a permit, it legally must be done correctly and inspected. DIYing permitted work can void your insurance and create sale problems.

07

CHAPTER 7

Finding & Vetting Contractors

How to avoid scams and find people you can trust

The best source: personal referrals from neighbors and friends who've had work done. Second best: NextDoor, Google reviews, and Angi (formerly Angie's List). Always: get 3 quotes for significant work. Ask for proof of license and insurance. Ask for references from similar jobs. Never pay more than 30% upfront. Get everything in writing: scope, materials, price, timeline. Red flags: door-to-door solicitation after a storm, pressure to decide immediately, cash-only or large upfront payment requirements.

08

CHAPTER 8

Home Insurance Deep Dive

What's covered, what's not, and how to lower your premium

Standard homeowner's insurance covers: fire, theft, most weather damage, liability. NOT covered by standard policy: floods (separate flood insurance required), earthquakes (separate in most states), normal wear and tear, mold (limited), sewer backup (usually an add-on). Lower your premium: higher deductible, bundle with auto insurance, security system discount, no claims history discount. Review coverage annually — many people are significantly underinsured.

09

CHAPTER 9

Building Home Equity

Smart improvements that actually increase value

High ROI improvements: kitchen remodel (minor, not gut renovation) 75–80% ROI, bathroom remodel 60–70%, new garage door 95%+ ROI, new front door 75% ROI, adding a bedroom (if possible) 50–70%, deck addition 65–75%. Low ROI: swimming pool (often negative in resale), over-the-top luxury finishes in average neighborhood, highly personalized design choices. Best equity strategy: maintain your home to prevent deterioration. Deferred maintenance is negative equity.

10

CHAPTER 10

Taxes as a Homeowner

Deductions and benefits you might be missing

Mortgage interest deduction: interest on up to \$750,000 of mortgage debt is deductible (itemize on Schedule A). Property tax deduction: up to \$10,000 of state/local taxes including property tax (SALT cap). Home office deduction: if you work from home and have a dedicated space, you can deduct a portion of home expenses. Capital gains exclusion: when you sell, up to \$250,000 (\$500,000 married) of gain is tax-free if you've lived there 2 of last 5 years.

11

CHAPTER 11

Smart Home Upgrades with Real ROI

What's worth spending money on

High value: smart thermostat (saves 10-15% on energy, \$150–250 cost), LED lighting throughout (significant long-term savings, low cost), programmable irrigation system (water savings + lawn health), video doorbell and smart locks (convenience + insurance discount potential). Skip or delay: home automation systems (complex, compatibility issues), smart appliances (premium cost, minimal practical benefit over standard).

12

CHAPTER 12

Long-Term Home Planning

Your 10-year maintenance and financial roadmap

Plan your major home expenses over time:

Years 1–3: Build home maintenance fund. Address any deferred issues from inspection. Minor cosmetic improvements.

Years 3–5: Minor kitchen or bathroom refresh if needed. Repaint exterior if necessary. HVAC check.

Years 5–10: Major system replacements may begin (roof, HVAC depending on age). Consider value-add improvements.

Years 10+: Major renovation consideration. Reassess whether home still fits your life stage.

My Home Maintenance Fund Goal & Progress:

GROWTHVAULT

Premium guides for people who want to grow.

growthvault.co